CLASS 2 HANDOUT

Reality & Feelings

Finding Peace Within

*Adapted from **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller*

What is it?

- Each individual has their own unique way of interpreting life
- Reality comes from within
- Reality is shaped by our history and the way we respond to the environment
- Two people can experience the same event
  - Both have different thoughts and feelings about the event
  - Both decide to take different actions in response to the event
- **The Five Areas** of our Reality
  - **THINKING**: Understanding how we think and give meaning to sensory input
  - **FEELING**: Recognizing and experiencing our emotions
  - **CHOICES & LIMITS**: The decisions we make, and what we will and won't do
  - **BEHAVIOR**: What we do and don't do; how it impacts others.
  - **BODY**: How we look and how our bodies function

Can you own it?

- People with complex trauma often say that they don't know who they are
- Being aware of the five areas of our Reality gives us a sense of who we are
- The Inner Journey is about accurately experiencing and sharing your personal environment
- Difficulty owning your reality means
  - Struggling to experience who you are, and share that with others
    - This can occur in any or all of the five areas (thinking, feeling, choices & limits, behavior, body)
  - We try to convince others of who we are (change their reality about us)
  - We try to control what others think to fulfill someone else's expectations
- Owning our reality is on a gradient.
  - We may not know our reality or we may know it, but we are not able to share it; or we may know our reality and be able to share it regardless of what others may think.
  - Where we are at on the gradient may depend on the situation that we are in or the people we are interacting with

Feelings

What generates them?

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- The four areas of **REALITY**
  - **BODY**:
    - Our five senses bring input from outer world to our inner world
  - **THINKING**:
    - We interpret, draw conclusions, and give meaning to the sensory input
  - **FEELING**:
    - Physiological response to our thoughts (also called emotions)
    - Uses up energy in our body
  - **BEHAVIOR**:
    - What we choose to do (or not do) as a result of our feelings
- Our belief system (based on our history and values) affects the way we think, feel, and behave
- How we process our thoughts impacts where our feelings go (positive or negative) & intensity of them
  - What we feel is what we feel
  - We cannot change our feelings
  - We can change our thoughts
- We learn to acknowledge it so we can process it
  - Denied feelings are a trigger for inappropriate behavior
  - Unprocessed feelings are stored in our bodies, they dont just dissapear because we choose not to process them

Tools for Feelings

- Allow yourself to feel them
  - Let them be as big (or little) and overwhelming/confusing (ugly) as they really are
- Find the truth
  - What/who is the source (external or internal)?
  - Is there an event that triggered it?
  - Use the True – Not True – Questionable Tool to separate the feelings from the thoughts
- Talk them out with a safe person
- Purge them
  - Journal? Art?
  - Physical: clean the house, beat up a pillow, break dishes, throw darts at a picture
  - Express them in a way that does not harm you, others, or valuable property

Feelings Chart

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Feeling (Reality)	Gift (Our Feelings)	Challenge (Induced or Carried Feelings)
Joy	Hope / Peace	
Pain	Change / Healing	Hopelessness / Depression
Anger	Energy / Power	Rage / Devalue
Fear	Protection / Wisdom	Panic / Paranoia / Helplessness
Guilt	Values / Integrity	False Guilt / Prolonged Guilt
Shame	Accountability / Fallibility (Limits)	Carried Shame / Shame Bound

Pain

*from **The Language of Letting Go** by Melody Beattie*

- Many sources of pain: history, current events, transitions or "life events"
- Our choice to
  - Let pain lead and guide us to a positive outcome (healthy choices/behaviors)
  - Stop or avoid pain (addictions, focus on others, denial/repression)
- Takes courage to stay still and feel - it will only hurt for awhile and then it will heal
- Can be confused with Anger

Anger

*from **Good 'n' Angry: How to Handle Your Anger Positively** by Les Carter*

- Three general ways people handle anger
- Repressed (denial)
  - If I ignore it, it will go away
  - Pushing from conscious to subconscious leads to it worsening
- Expressed (outwardly communicated)
  - Assertive: respects the dignity/value of another
  - Aggressive: without regard for other person's worth/value
- Released (let it go)
  - Making the conscious decision that anger is no longer needed
  - Must first be able to assertively express anger
- Can be confused with Pain

Fear

*from **Feel the Fear & Do It Anyway** by Susan Jeffers*

- Fear is a part of life
  - Wings: It can be a companion on this journey of life and we take flight
  - Anchor: It can become an anchor and we become frozen (in fear)
- By confronting a situation or "doing something"
  - Fear gradually decreases
  - Self-confidence and self-worth increase
- Fear does not equal isolation
- Fearing fear is worse than facing fear (helplessness)

Guilt

*from **Mind Over Emotions** by Les Carter*

- Communicates that something is amiss in our thinking and behavior
- True Guilt
  - Inner voice to live a moral, responsible life
- False Guilt
  - Feeling of remorse that is judgmental toward oneself
  - Decreases value/self-worth and increases fear of being "found out" and punished
- Creates a sense of isolation
- Usually is accompanied by Shame

Shame

*from **Letting Go of Shame** by Ronald and Patricia Potter-Efron*

- Represents a person's identity
- Defense mechanisms: denial, perfectionism, arrogance, exhibitionism, rage
- Become aware of your shame and examine it even though we want to hide from it
  - Where does your shame come from? (society, family, significant other, yourself)
- Shame heals when shared with another
- Set positive goals and take responsibility for reformating your thoughts and changing your behaviors
- Usually is accompanied by Guilt

What is the goal?

- Definition of a healthy, mature adult:
  - A person who can share their reality with another person without judgement or a need to fix, change, or teach anything
- We accomplish this by learning to acknowledge, own, express, and support our reality
- We learn to accept others without judgment.

Reasons we refrain from telling others who we are

- Fear of rejection
- We are not sure who we are or what we want to say
- We have been inhibited and controlled by family (or family rules)
- We believe it is NOT okay to be who we are
- We don't like ourselves
- We don't trust our thoughts
- We don't trust our feelings
- We don't think our opinions are valuable
- We don't think we have the right to say no
- We are not sure what we need or want
- We feel guilty about our needs and wants
- We feel ashamed of our problems
- We don't trust our ability to identify problems

Reality Tools

- Be aware
  - Are others wanting to change your reality or are you wanting to change another's reality? Did you give another permission to share their thoughts?
- Claim it
  - Learn to surface, own, express, and support your own reality by becoming aware of your body, thoughts, feelings, and behaviors
- Own it
  - Where are you at on the gradient and how do you strengthen your sense of reality by bringing your reality into your awareness then expressing your reality to others
- Practice
  - Allowing others to have their own reality even when it conflicts with your reality (about yourself)
- TRUE – NOT TRUE - QUESTIONABLE
  - Use a situation that you are dealing with, and ask yourself questions to find the truth of the situation (this may require a safe person to help give you perspective)
  - The question you ask yourself is **Is it True, Not True, or Questionable that ...**

True, not true, or questionable: start extreme

Ask yourself: **"Is it True, Not True, or Questionable that…?"** Start with the most extreme thing your feelings are telling you (it's usually easy to call that one *Not true*), then step down one notch at a time until you reach the facts and your feelings.

- True: **own it**. It's your reality; express it and take care of it.
- Not true: **let it go**.
- Questionable: **check it out**. Ask the person, talk with a safe person, or wait.

Listen for the extremes: "…this will never get better?" · "…I always mess this up?" · "…this means I'm not good enough?" · "…they think ___?" · "…___ actually happened?" · "…I feel ___?"

EXAMPLE: "MY FRIEND DIDN'T TEXT ME BACK ALL DAY"

Is it True, Not True, or Questionable that…	
…nobody will ever love me?	Not true
…my friend hates me?	Not true: we had lunch last week and she hugged me goodbye
…I did something to upset her?	Questionable: I don't know
…she's angry with me?	Questionable
…she didn't text me back today?	True
…I feel hurt and anxious?	True

Own: I feel hurt and anxious. **Let go:** "nobody loves me," "she hates me." **Check out:** is she upset? Ask her, or wait and see.

Exercise: Start extreme, then dial in

What happened (something someone said or did that stung):

Is it True, Not True, or Questionable that…	Circle one
…	T NT Q
…	T NT Q
…	T NT Q
…	T NT Q
…	T NT Q
…	T NT Q

Own (true):

Let go (not true):

Check out (questionable), and how:

Take-home: Practice True, Not True, or Questionable

Once this week, when something stings, ask "Is it True, Not True, or Questionable?" Start with the most extreme thing your feelings are telling you, then step down to the facts and your feelings.

What happened:

Is it True, Not True, or Questionable that...	Circle one
...	T NT Q
...	T NT Q
...	T NT Q
...	T NT Q
...	T NT Q

Own:

Let go:

Check out:

How did I feel afterward?

Group Questions

Check-in first What color did you get? Did anything about it surprise you?

Answer from whichever level fits where you are tonight. It's fine to stay in Start.

Start

JUST STARTING OUT

1. Which part of your reality is easiest for you to share: your thoughts, your feelings, or what you do?

2. What is one feeling you've had this week?

Go deeper

APPLY TONIGHT'S IDEAS

3. Which part of your reality (body, thinking, feeling, behavior) is hardest to share with others, and what makes it feel risky?

4. Where in your life could you use True, Not True, or Questionable right now, and what's the first extreme question you'd ask?

Stretch

FOR A BIGGER CHALLENGE

5. What feeling is hardest for you to let yourself feel? What do you do instead?

6. When do you try to convince someone else of who you are, instead of letting them have their own reality?